



What's your take on the last few months' trend, which saw more demand than supply? Is it actually a marketer's dream?

As a marketing person, I could say it was marketing that brought in all the new customers that we've seen in the last year and a half, but that wouldn't be the whole truth. Because we know that having inventory was the key thing. At Mouser, we know we need to always be marketing ourselves. There's always new technologies, products and services to talk about.

What has been Mouser's investment trend in marketing?

At Mouser, there's never downtime for marketing to take time off. Every year, we continue to invest more, and we hire more people. I think our biggest advantage is having the local marketing teams throughout the world to deliver our core competency messages to our customers. There are a lot of companies that stop investing in marketing when business starts to slow down, or maybe steady out. But for us, that's the time to invest more. Because if everybody else is pulling back, we should be out there in front of all the engineers and all the buyers.

Talking about your personal background, you have a degree in logistics, and you started off in warehouse operations. How did you make the transition?

I did start out in the warehouse by stocking parts and pulling orders. Then I moved into different supervisory management roles within our global distribution centre. And then one day, someone came and said, "Hey, would you like to be in sales/customer service as a manager?" I had never done customer service, nor had I done sales. But I said that I'd learn to love another part of the company. So, I went into customer service. Around 2004-05, Mouser's

marketing was being done by the products team and the sales team. And this was back in the days when all you did was put ads in print publications and printed catalogs to mail to customers.

So, how did this big marketing team take shape? What all did you invest your time and energy in?

We believed that the head of the new marketing team would take over catalogue production and advertising as well. And business expansion would also be a part of their role, which included opening our first office outside of Texas, in Singapore. So, we went ahead and created a marketing team. I didn't know marketing, but I've learned to love it. And I will tell you that most of the learning on marketing is just spending time with smart people, media, and manufacturers, and understanding their expectations while simultaneously building a strong team to deliver. And we need to be nimble to do stuff quickly, to change, to add something new.

What's your secret sauce to identify the right people for the right position?

I try to hire people smarter than me, which isn't very hard. But the biggest thing that I'm a proponent of is, teamwork. Also, if I bring somebody in, I expect them to be an expert in their domain. I should not have to drive everything. I'm there to support the experts and provide them with the tools to succeed. Lastly, I'll give them my feedback, too, whether it's good or bad. But to me, it's giving responsibility to people with the right skill set and letting them try things, whether it fails or succeeds.

Did your warehouse experience help you see various aspects of the business?

Yes, you said it perfectly. Because what I learned in the

warehouse, by just talking to people around Mouser, gave me an understanding of not only the company's philosophy, mission statement, and goals, but also our customer base. There are a lot of people that have a great background in B2C-type marketing or consumer-type marketing, which will not always work in our industry. If you don't understand your customers, you will do a poor job at marketing.

In some media campaigns, the platforms provide the end results as a part of the deliverables, which raises the possibility of cheating. Are you experiencing this challenge?

That's a tough question to answer. I wish there wasn't cheating going on. Do I have suspicions that it goes on? Yes, absolutely. Because some of the numbers don't match. But it is tough to accuse a partner of doing so. We bet on relationships and partnerships with the people we work with. And we hope that the trust we have in them to bring new customers by delivering our message to their customer base is in good hands.

There is also a trend of collaborating with influencers on social media. What are Mouser's thoughts on this?

Yes, influencers can really help build new communities, and we are seeing traction around that. We have come across lots of influencers, who are actually the engineers and customers who prototype the samples. And their followers are increasing on a daily basis, and likewise are our subscribers. We have some third-party influencers who are not biased, but they usually unbox a product they bought from Mouser, or they use some components from Mouser in their prototypes. But more than advertising, social media has to be engaging. And globally, our social media teams are figuring out what type of content is most relevant to our audiences. **EFY**